likely to have had a symbolic spiritual dominance in the lived world of ancient communities within this area. Such communities climbed the hill on specific ceremonial occasions. The pre-existence of sacredness associated with a hilltop explains its reuse. The edicts, in turn, transformed the place. Jatinga-Rameshwara was probably a local or at best provincial religious spot. Ashoka's message made it part of a web of places connected to each other by the imprimatur of an emperor who ruled from the Himalayas to the hills of Karnataka and beyond.

How did people who trudged here to pay obeisance to their own deities respond to the Buddhist message? There will have been many kinds of responses, from rapt interest to scarcely concealed indifference. However, by contrast with the Brahmagiri rock—which even in the modern era was seen as endowed with special properties—Jatinga-Rameshwara's ancient spiritual mission was rendered quotidian over time. At the time that the Ashokan edict rock was discovered in the late nineteenth century, it had become the favourite spot of bangle-sellers hawking their wares to pilgrims. The rock was called 'balegara-gundu', or bangle-sellers' rock; various holes were punched into it for posts that supported a tent erected by them at the annual fair.[46] An ancient sacred space later marked by an emperor's new-found spirituality now supported a more mundane and entirely material quest.

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If unprepossessing iron-using communities with remarkable grave-building traditions dominated the places in Karnataka where Ashoka's early edicts were inscribed, an entirely different repertoire of associations existed around the king's message at Panguraria in Central India.

A forested hilly tract with a range of rock shelters is how one might describe the landscape of Panguraria. It is a place with rock paintings done very many centuries before Ashoka even as it carries a strong resonance of